

Elon Musk vs Sam Altman: AI breakup that refuses to end

When two tech titans clash, the result isn't ideal for anyone

—By **Jayesh Shinde**

It's Silicon Valley's most prolonged breakup, this continuing saga of Sam Altman and Elon Musk, co-founders turned courtroom combatants — over not just OpenAI but the future of AI itself. The kind where one side moves on, launches a new company, builds a massive global brand, gets the world talking — and the other keeps showing up uninvited at the party, refusing to get over and move forward.

future plans. If the original lawsuit Musk filed in 2024 was about “mission drift,” this countersuit is about harassment.

A timeline of feud

Let's rewind for a second, and understand how it all went wrong for Elon Musk with respect to OpenAI, and how the relationship between him and Sam Altman further deteriorated over the past few years.

Back in 2015, Sam Altman and Elon Musk were part of the founding dream team of OpenAI — a nonprofit set up

In 2023, Elon Musk launched xAI to build Grok, a ChatGPT rival that's part AI assistant, part Twitter troll. By early 2024, he'd accused OpenAI of selling out — saying it had gone from nonprofit to profit-first, losing its moral compass. He filed a lawsuit against OpenAI, later withdrawing it. Then refiled it, adding Microsoft for good measure.

In January 2025, Altman appeared alongside President Donald Trump to unveil the Stargate initiative — a mind-bending \$500 billion project to build AI data centers. The next day, Elon Musk called Sam Altman a “swindler” and “liar.” Because of course he did.

Root of the grievance

At the heart of Elon Musk's grievance is his strong belief that OpenAI has strayed from its founding mission. What started as a nonprofit has now morphed into a capped-profit model, with plans to shift into a public benefit corporation — meaning it's still mission-oriented, but with revenue goals attached.

OpenAI doesn't see this as betrayal from its core mission — it sees it as necessary evolution. A lot of money is the basic fuel driving the engine of cutting-edge AI evolution, whether you or Elon Musk likes it or not.

Sam Altman has OpenAI to run. He's leading arguably the most influential AI company on the planet, working on models that will shape education, creativity, communication, and perhaps a lot more. Elon Musk has his hands full too — there's SpaceX, Tesla, xAI, Neuralink, and a rapidly evolving platform in X.

Maybe, just maybe, the energy spent fighting each other could be better used actually building the futures they are so invested in. Shouldn't there finally be some peace? tinyurl.com/4mck3p3v



Earlier in April, OpenAI filed a countersuit against Musk, asking the court to formally hit pause on what it described as a campaign of “unlawful and unfair action.” Sam Altman is basically saying that enough is enough to Elon Musk.

The lawsuit, filed in California, claims Elon Musk's recent moves — including a dramatic \$97.4 billion “takeover bid” in February 2025 to acquire OpenAI's nonprofit arm — weren't just stunts. They were calculated disruptions. The company even called the bid “fake,” designed to interfere with OpenAI's

with the noble (and very Muskian) mission to keep AI beneficial to humanity. Not necessarily profitable. Just safe, fair, and accessible.

But in 2018, Elon Musk stepped down from the OpenAI board. On paper, it was to avoid a conflict of interest with Tesla's own AI developments. Behind the scenes, there were disagreements — over OpenAI's long term direction, over leadership, and (according to various reports) over OpenAI's control. Since then, their relationship has gone from quietly tense to publicly toxic.